

The good thing is, you can extend its capabilities from the third-party plug-ins available on its website. It offers media streaming from YouTube, Hulu and Veoh with the help of plug-ins, besides other expandability options that you can add. There's even a weather applet that can fetch weather forecasts for your city [if available] from the Web, and display it on the main screen.

And the party's over

I find XBMC's interface and media streaming capabilities quite impressive. No matter what codec a file needs, the player is capable of playing it smoothly. Playing a full HD 1080p movie on it is an unmatched experience—the surroundings are drenched with divine acoustics, and my family and friends are mesmerised by the stunning experience the media player offers.

However, the player is very

resource hungry. It uses 50 per cent of the CPU cycles of my quad core system, besides eating up a whopping 1.8 GB of RAM. On the other hand, SMplayer/VLC only uses 25-30 per cent of the CPU and ~750MB of RAM.

In addition, coming with a 'Media Centre' tag, XBMC

should include much more media centre capabilities, but they are nowhere to be found; also, there are no proper alternatives to these missing capabilities.

Overall, although XBMC does try to steal the limelight, there are more negatives than positives. Because of its resource hogging nature and lack of media centre capabilities, it comes across as a mediocre media centre. So if you plan to build a HTPC, look for an alternative. 

XBMC 9.04.1



Pros: Easy to use, eye catching interface, media streaming capabilities, lots of navigation options, expandability.

Cons: Resource hungry, no Media Center capabilities, no support for USB 2.0 and multisession medium. No support for DRM files.

Platform: Linux, MS Windows, Mac OS, Apple TV, Xbox

Price: Free (as in beer)

Website: www.xbmc.org

Resources

- Home Page: xbmc.org
- Wikipedia: en.wikipedia.org/wiki/XBMC

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The author is a FOSS/hardware enthusiast who likes to review software and tweak his hardware for optimum performance. He is interested in Python/Qt programming and fond of benchmarking the latest distros and applications.

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